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SUSHIL KUMAR



MARY KOM

TRAILBLAZERS Wrestling icon Sushil Kumar, an Olympic silver medallist at Beijing 2008 and bronze medallist at London 2012, won gold at the 2010 and 2014 Commonwealth Games; (right) Mary Kom's multiple world boxing titles during the decade crowned a journey of extraordinary resilience

It was a decade in which Indian sport experienced a rare convergence of triumph and turbulence. Victories lifted national confidence, individual athletes rewrote gendered and cultural expectations, and cricket reinvented itself as a global entertainment industry. At the same time, scandal, corruption and excess revealed the cost of rapid commercialisation.

The high point came in April 2011, when India lifted the ICC Cricket World Cup at the Wankhede Stadium. Twenty-eight years after Kapil Dev's team had stunned the world, Mahendra Singh Dhoni's side delivered a victory that felt both historic and inevitable. Dhoni's calm leadership, the emergence of a new core of players and a home crowd's emotional crescendo turned the final into a generational moment. The image of Sachin Tendulkar being carried on teammates' shoulders symbolised not just a win, but the closing of a circle that had defined Indian cricket for two decades.

That victory had been foreshadowed earlier in the decade by India's breakthrough at the inaugural ICC World Twenty20 in 2007. A young, underestimated team, led by a rookie captain, embraced the shortest format of the game with fearless intent. The title did more than add a trophy. It marked a cultural shift, giving Indian cricket a new generation of decision-makers and accelerating the sport's transformation into a fast-paced, television-driven spectacle.

Parallel to cricket's dominance was a quieter but profound expansion of India's sporting imagination. In 2008, Abhinav Bindra won India's first-ever individual Olym-

LEADING LADIES: Sania Mirza and Saina Nehwal (R) shattered long-standing ceilings in Indian sport. Sania became the first Indian woman to crack the world's top ranks, while Saina carried Indian badminton from the margins to the centre of global competition, winning major titles



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